



reach the top of the supports, pinch out the growing tips. In order to produce pods, it is crucial that beans not be allowed to dry out once pollinated, so mulch around the bases of the plants, and water frequently.

HARVESTING

If beans are left too long they will become tough and stringy, so harvest when they are still young and tender; this may be up to two or three times a week. This will also encourage the plants to produce more pods. Beans do not store long, but seeds can be stored for future crops.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Discourage the diseases that affect runner beans, such as halo blight and foot and root rot, by practicing careful crop rotation—plant where root crops have grown the previous year. Halo blight causes dark spots ringed with yellow “haloes” on leaves. Remove and destroy any infected plants.

Black bean aphids are strongly attracted to the growing tips, so pinch these out when plants have reached full height. Bad infestations may need treating with an insecticide. Mice may eat seed sown in the soil.